First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 7
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Earth
18 October 2026

Preaching: ML
Worship Leading: LVF & Sharon Duncan
Musical Leadership: Brandon Harris

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Laura and Sharon center chancel]

Welcome **LVF**

Words of Gathering **SD & LVF**
As we gather this morning,
listen to these words that call us
to consider the world around us:

We do not have to go
to Sacred Places
in far-off lands.
The ground on which
we abide is holy.

Here, in this small garden
we tend
our pilgrimage ends.
The wild honeybees
the hummingbird moths
the flickering fireflies at dusk
are a microcosm
of the Universe.

Each seed that grows
each spade of soil
is full of miracles.

And we toil and sweat
and watch and wonder
and we are full of love.

Living in place
in this place,
for truth and beauty
dwell here.

["Earth praises" By Mary de La Valette. Earth Prayers]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.

***Hymn of Gathering**

[Laura center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness** **LVF**

Holy One, it is in the depths of life that we find you,
at the heart of this moment,
at the center of our soul,
deep in the earth and its eternal stirrings.
You are the Ground of all being,
the Well-Spring of all time,
Womb of the earth,
the Seed-Force of stars.

And so at the opening of this day
we wait,
not for blessings from afar,
but for You,
the very Soil of our soul,
the early Freshness of morning,
the first Breath of Day.
Amen and Amen! [JPhilipNewell]

***Introit** I am the Earth Täht and Valjayaga
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

[Sharon to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer** **SD**

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**
Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace** **LVF**

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[Sharon to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition ***from Exodus*** **SD**

This is the witness of the people.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph short transition Laura center chancel]

Prayers with the People **LVF**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

—

As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write the prayers of our hearts for our lives and the life of our world on the slips of paper in our programs. If you are online, please share your prayers by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Then, as the music begins, we are invited to come forward to share our prayers here in the bowl, and to light candles signifying our prayers, for ourselves, those we love and hold dear - and for the life of the world.

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

[Christoph transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem Gather at the River Stacey V. Gibbs
Laude, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

[Christoph transition Michael to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon ***Sacred Earth*** **ML**

[Christoph transition Sharon to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity **SD**

Gardens QR Code

Offertory Anthem When Our Dreams Take Flight Music: Dr. Rollo Dilworth
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor* Text:Paul Laurence Dunbar

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**
From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Sharon to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Offering Prayer** **SD**

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church **ML & LVF**
+Thanks, Grace and Greg, for sponsoring today's Coffee Hour in honor of our Deacons!

+Introducing Emma Phillips, our new Farm Manager!
+Events this week: Men's Group, Not Your Grandma's Bible Study, Gardens Workday
+Fall Festival- October 25. Chili signups!

Words of Blessing **ML**

Choral Response Beulah Land Stacey V. Gibbs
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

***Hymn for the Journey**

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Inside The Music- Brandon Harris

Today, as we reflect on the theme of **Sacred Earth**, we are invited to consider our relationship with the Earth, our responsibility to one another, and the holiness that surrounds us.

We begin with Täht and Valjayaga's *I Am the Earth*, a musical expression of our personal connection to the ground beneath our feet. When we recognize the Earth as an extension of ourselves, we are called to care for it with the same tenderness, respect, and love we would offer our own bodies. In embracing this shared responsibility, our individual acts of care become a collective expression of reverence for the sacred world we have been given.

Laude presents Stacey V. Gibbs' arrangement of *Gather at the River*, a song that evokes the biblical imagery of the River of Life. Rivers sustain the Earth, nourish its inhabitants, and remind us of the life-giving resources upon which our existence depends. As we gather at the river in song, we are invited to reflect on the ways these sacred waters sustain not only our physical lives but also our spiritual journeys through a world that is both beautiful and complex.

Rollo Dilworth's *When Our Dreams Take Flight*, inspired by Paul Laurence Dunbar's poem "Dreams," explores the fragile yet enduring nature of our hopes and ambitions. Through vivid images drawn from the natural world, including rosy clouds and withering flowers, Dunbar reflects on the vulnerability of dreams and the sorrow that can accompany their loss. Dilworth's warm, accessible Gospel harmonies offer a message of hope: when we come together in community, we can encourage one another, nurture our aspirations, and help one another's dreams take flight.

Finally, the Cathedral Choir offers an excerpt from Gibbs' *Beulah Land*, a powerful expression of the longing for a promised land of freedom, peace, and joy. For some, this land represents the heavenly home toward which we journey; for others, it inspires a vision of liberation and wholeness that we can begin to realize here on Earth. Through our commitment to justice, our care for creation, and our love for one another, we participate in making this sacred ground a place where freedom and joy can flourish.

As we listen, may the music awaken us to the holiness of the Earth beneath our feet. Like Moses before the burning bush, may we pause in reverence, recognize the divine presence in the world around us, and remember that this sacred ground is both a gift to cherish and a responsibility to uphold.